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Optimal Control and Reinforcement Learning

Course Project 2 - Flexible Robotic Link

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Abstract

This project addresses the optimal control and trajectory tracking of a flexible robotic link, modeled as an under-actuated planar double pendulum with nonlinear joint stiffness.

The goal of this work is to develop a comprehensive framework for trajectory generation and tracking control, considering the system's inherent nonlinearities and actuation constraints.

The study adopts a flexible discretization framework where the integration scheme is selected based on the specific requirements of the maneuver and its required fidelity. The analytic Jacobians are derived directly from the chosen discrete-time mapping, ensuring that the gradients remain consistent with the state-transition dynamics.

We analyze the system's equilibrium manifold to identify stable and unstable configurations.

Trajectory generation is performed using a Newton-based approach. Moreover, a novel Dynamic Horizon Extension strategy is proposed to enhance the convergence of trajectory optimization algorithms in the presence of complex dynamics.

Finally, we implement and compare two tracking controllers: a Linear Time-Varying Linear Quadratic Regulator (LTV-LQR) for unconstrained stabilization, and a Model Predictive Control (MPC) scheme to handle actuator saturation.

Simulation results demonstrate the efficacy of the proposed extension strategy in generating feasible trajectories and highlight the superior performance of MPC in tracking under input constraints.

Introduction

This report presents the design and implementation of optimal control strategies for a flexible robotic link. The system is modeled as a planar double pendulum where only the first joint is actuated, and a nonlinear elastic behavior is present at the end of the second link.

This structure introduces significant control challenges, specifically:

- **Under-actuation:** The system has two degrees of freedom (DoF) but only one control input (torque at the base);
- **Nonlinear Elasticity:** The stiffness between the links depends nonlinearly on the relative angle θ_2, complicating the dynamics compared to standard linear springs;
- **Non-controllability:** The system is not fully feedback linearizable, and maintaining equilibrium requires precise balancing of gravitational and elastic forces;
- **Low Friction:** The provided parameters (Set 2) involve relatively low friction coefficients, making the system prone to oscillations and sensitive to disturbances.

1 Task 0: Problem Setup and Discretization

The double pendulum model used in this project is reported in Figure 1.



Figure 1: Double Pendulum System with flexible link.

The configuration vector is defined as: $q = \begin{bmatrix}\theta_1 & \theta_2\end{bmatrix}^\top \in \mathbb{R}^n$. With $n = 2$ degrees of freedom. The continuous-time dynamics of the double pendulum are governed by the equation:

$$M(q)\ddot{q} + C(q,\dot{q})\dot{q} + F\dot{q} + G(q) = \begin{bmatrix}\tau \\ 0\end{bmatrix} \tag{1}$$

Where[1]:

- $M(q) = M(q)^\top \succeq 0 \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ is the inertia matrix;
- $C(q,\dot{q}) = C(q,\dot{q})^\top \succeq 0 \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ represents Coriolis and centrifugal forces;
- $F = F^\top \succeq 0 \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ is the viscous friction matrix;
- $G(q)$ is the gravity vector;
- $\tau \in \mathbb{R}^{n_i}$ is the control torque applied at the first joint[2] with $n_i = 1$.

The adopted parameters for this system are summarized in Table 1.

The state space vector is defined to include both positions and velocities: $x = \begin{bmatrix}\theta_1 & \theta_2 & \dot{\theta}_1 & \dot{\theta}_2\end{bmatrix}^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{n_s}$. With $n_s = 2n = 4$ states. Thus, the continuous time state-space nonlinear dynamics can be expressed as:

$$\dot{x} = f(x,u) = \begin{bmatrix}\dot{q} & \ddot{q}\end{bmatrix}^\top = \begin{bmatrix}\dot{\theta}_1 & \dot{\theta}_2 & \ddot{\theta}_1 & \ddot{\theta}_2\end{bmatrix}^\top. \tag{2}$$

Where:

- $u = \tau \in \mathbb{R}$ control input;
- $f : \mathbb{R}^{n_s} \times \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}^{n_s}$ is a nonlinear function representing the system dynamics.

1.1 Discretization Methods

Two discretization schemes has been implemented in `solver.py`[3].

[1] The detailed expressions for $M(q)$, $C(q,\dot{q})$, F, and $G(q)$ can be found in the Appendix 13.1.
[2] In this tractation are not considered non-conservative forces or contact forces.
[3] Details in Appendix 13.3

1. **Forward Euler (FE):**

$$x_{k+1} = x_k + \Delta t f(x_k, u_k) \tag{3}$$

   While simple, this method is numerically unstable for stiff systems or large time steps;

2. **Runge-Kutta 4th Order (RK4):**

$$x_{k+1} = x_k + \frac{\Delta t}{6}(k_1 + 2k_2 + 2k_3 + k_4) \tag{4}$$

   This method maps all poles of the continuous-time system to within the unit circle in the discrete-time domain, ensuring stability. However, its computation time is higher that FE.

Where:

- Δt is the discretization time step;
- x_k, u_k are the state and control input at time step k;
- k_1, k_2, k_3, k_4 are the RK4 intermediate slopes.

1.2 Analytic Jacobian Computation

For the Newton-based optimal control algorithm, accurate gradients of the dynamics are required. Relying on finite differences can introduce numerical noise, while symbolic differentiation (via `SymPy`) proved too slow for iterative solving.

Therefore, we implemented an **analytic Jacobian** computation in `model.py`.

- $A = \frac{\partial f(x,u)}{\partial x} = \nabla_1 f(x,u)^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{n_s \times n_s}$: State Jacobian;
- $B = \frac{\partial f(x,u)}{\partial u} = \nabla_2 f(x,u)^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{n_s \times n_i}$: Input Jacobian;

The Jacobians were derived manually and implemented using optimized NumPy operations (and Numba JIT compilation for speed). This approach ensures that the linearization required for the Backward Pass in Newton's method is both precise and computationally efficient. The detailed derivation is reported in Appendix 13.2.

2 Task 1: Equilibria and Terminal Cost

2.1 Equilibrium Manifold

The system's equilibria are defined by states where $\dot{q} = \ddot{q} = 0$. This implies the gravity and stiffness torques must be balanced by the input τ. We analyzed the equilibrium manifold by fixing one generalized coordinate (θ_1 or θ_2) and solving for the other.

$$\cancel{M(\theta_1,\theta_2)\begin{pmatrix}\ddot{\theta}_1\\ \ddot{\theta}_2\end{pmatrix}} + \cancel{C(\theta_1,\theta_2,\dot{\theta}_1,\dot{\theta}_2)\begin{pmatrix}\dot{\theta}_1\\ \dot{\theta}_2\end{pmatrix}} + \cancel{F\begin{pmatrix}\dot{\theta}_1\\ \dot{\theta}_2\end{pmatrix}} + G(\theta_1,\theta_2) = \begin{pmatrix}0\\ \tau\end{pmatrix} \tag{5}$$

This reduces to:

$$\underbrace{\begin{pmatrix} gl_{c1}m_1\sin(\theta_1) + gm_2(l_1\sin(\theta_1) + l_{c2}\sin(\theta_1+\theta_2)) \\ gm_2l_{c2}\sin(\theta_1+\theta_2) + 3k\sin(\theta_2)\cos^2(\theta_2)\end{pmatrix}}_{G(\theta_1,\theta_2)} = \underbrace{\begin{pmatrix}0\\ \tau\end{pmatrix}}_{\tau} \tag{6}$$

In this framework, we have three variables: θ_1, θ_2, and τ. By fixing one of the three variables, we can solve for the other two. It looks natural, since we are interested in obtaining specific configurations, and since the first joint is actuated, to fix θ_1 and solve for θ_2 and τ.

Using this approach, we generate an equilibrium manifold that is a function of the first joint angle θ_1. It is worth noting that two distinct configurations arise for each θ_1 value, corresponding to different θ_2 angles (e.g., "Elbow-Up" and "Elbow-Down" positions). They will respectively be stable and unstable equilibria.

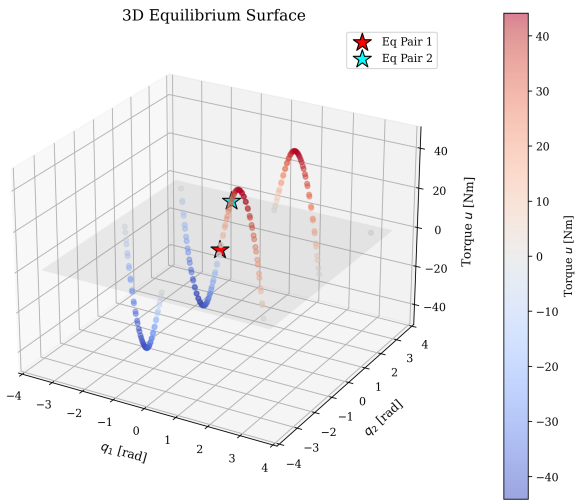


Figure 2: 3D Equilibrium manifold.

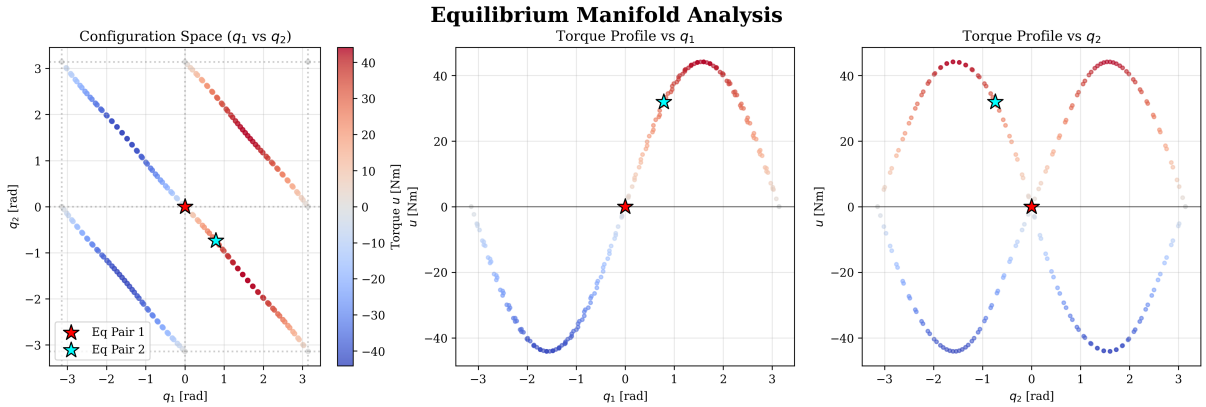


Figure 3: Equilibrium manifold as a function of θ_1.

The first thing we can see is that the manifold has a sinusoidal shape and a periodic behavior, which is expected given the rotational nature of the joints and the influence of gravity. From the plot, we can also observe some important characteristics:

- **Branches** We can say that the manifold is **constituted by branches**, hence there will be starting and ending equilibria that are on the same branch and others that will be in two different ones.
  This will have an impact on the trajectory generation, as moving between different branches may **require more complex maneuvers**.

- **Uncontrolled second arm** Since the second joint is unactuated, the torque τ is only applied at the first joint.
  This means that the system's ability to reach certain **configurations** in a given **time** is **limited by the dynamics of the second link** and the coupling between the two joints. This coupling will prove useful in achieving a stabilization of the second link by appropriately controlling the first one. We will see this is **not always possible**, and this causes problems in trajectory generation when trying to reach certain target equilibria and mantain them for some time.

2.2 Cost Function

For the optimal control problem, we defined the quadratic cost function:

$$J = \sum_{t=0}^{T-1} \left(\frac{1}{2} \Delta x_t^\top Q \Delta x_t + \frac{1}{2} \Delta u_t^\top R \Delta u_t \right) + \frac{1}{2} \Delta x_T^\top Q_T \Delta x_T \tag{7}$$

where $\Delta x = x - x_{ref}$ and $\Delta u = u - u_{ref}$. We selected $Q = \text{diag}(1, 1, 1, 1)$ and $R = 10^{-3} I$ to penalize state deviation while allowing for aggressive control actions.

2.3 Terminal Cost via DARE

A critical aspect of the finite-horizon optimization is the terminal cost Q_T. Simply setting $Q_T = Q$ often fails to stabilize the system at the end of the horizon, especially for short durations. In fact, without an appropriate terminal cost, the solver may produce trajectories that approach but do not settle at the desired equilibrium, leading to oscillations or drift post-optimization. It is as if the optimizer result was **"myopic"**, focusing only on minimizing cost up to time T without considering the long-term behavior beyond this point. To address this, we computed Q_T by solving the **Discrete Algebraic Riccati Equation** (DARE) based on the linearization at the final target equilibrium (x_{eq}, u_{eq}).

$$P_\infty = A^\top P_\infty A - (A^\top P_\infty B)(R + B^\top P_\infty B)^{-1}(B^\top P_\infty A) + Q \tag{8}$$

Setting $Q_T = P_\infty$ provides an approximation of the infinite-horizon cost-to-go. This essentially informs the solver that the trajectory continues optimally after time T, significantly improving convergence and stability for tasks like the "Swing Up".

2.4 Step Size Selection (Armijo Rule)

To ensure global convergence of the Newton method, we implemented a **line search using the Armijo rule**. The step size α is reduced ($\alpha \leftarrow \beta\alpha$) until the actual cost reduction is a sufficient fraction of the predicted reduction (based on the gradient). This prevents the solver from taking overly aggressive steps that could destabilize the trajectory and **ensures steady progress towards the optimum**. Additionally, the implementation includes a gradient check that validates the analytic descent direction by comparing it to a numeric slope $\frac{J(u+\epsilon\Delta u)-J(u)}{\epsilon}$ computed via finite difference. If the Armijo search fails to satisfy the sufficient decrease condition within the maximum allowed iterations, the **step size is set to zero** to prevent the update and safeguard the solver from adopting an unstable or divergent trajectory. Here there are some plots of the Armijo line search behavior during the trajectory optimization.

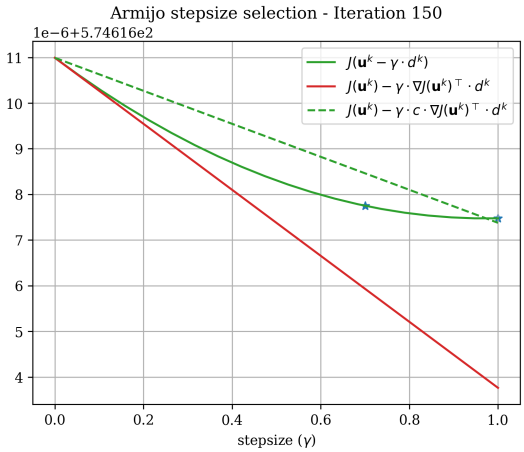


Figure 4: Armijo line search behavior A.

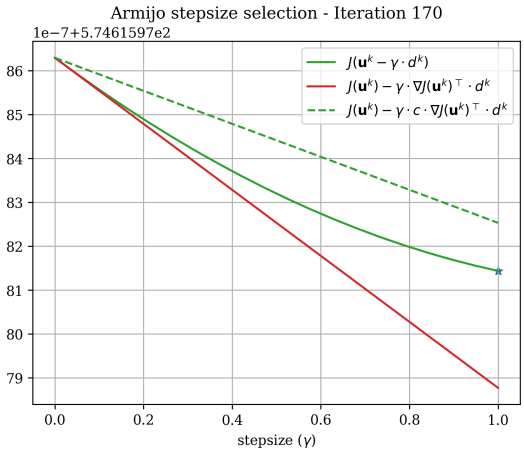


Figure 5: Armijo line search behavior B.

3 Task 2: Trajectory Generation (Newton's Method)

We employed a Newton-type method for optimal control (Differential Dynamic Programming approach) to generate trajectories transitioning between equilibria.

3.1 Reference Generation

The non-convex nature of the problem requires a reasonable reference trajectory, even though not feasible. We explored two reference generation methods:

1. **Stepwise:** A naive instantaneous switch from start to goal. This often results in poor convergence due to the large discontinuity.
2. **Polynomial Interpolation (Poly 5):** We generated smooth references for positions and velocities using 5th-order polynomials. This provided a kinematic guide that respects boundary conditions, significantly aiding the solver.



Figure 6: stepwise reference trajectory



Figure 7: poly 5 reference trajectory

3.1.1 Tasks definition

Swing up



Figure 8: poly 5 reference trajectory

Swing down



Figure 9: poly 5 reference trajectory

complex manouver



Figure 10: poly 5 reference trajectory

3.2 Newton's method applied to Stepwise reference trajectory

Example of stepwise applied to swing up



Figure 11: poly 5 reference trajectory

Problem of trajectory (big jump on u right at the transition)

3.3 Newton's method applied to polynomial reference trajectory

Example of polynomial applied to swing up



Figure 12: poly 5 reference trajectory

Example of polynomial applied to swing down



Figure 13: poly 5 reference trajectory

- when doing elbow up kinematic energy gets transferred to potential energy
- when doing elbow down there is no way to stop the second link using by subtracting kinetic energy
- friction is low and we cannot rely on that to dissipate energy fast enough

Example of polynomial applied to swing down complex manouver



Figure 14: poly 5 reference trajectory

Applying the standard Newton method directly to complex maneuvers revealed several issues:

- **Local Minima:** Being the manouver complex and the time horizon large, there would be many local minimum in the Loss landscape. When using an initial guess that is far off from the real trajectory, it pushes the loss far away from the local minimum that guarantees a solution. Once we land inside a minimum, it is not possible to move out of it.



Figure 15: poly 5 reference trajectory

Using instead a smaller time horizon, the loss landscape has few local minima, therefore is possible to find an easier solution, but it's not possible to converge exactly to the equilibrium in time. We must choose a compromise.



Figure 16: poly 5 reference trajectory

- **Assumption on controllability:** If we apply DARE to find the final cost matrix Q_T, we are assuming that from the last point on, the system has completely converged to the equilibrium.
-

1. controllability 2. ill-conditioning 3. long time horizons (search tree troppo grande e tanti local local minima nel manifold) 4. explosions nelle condizioni instabili

3.4 Dynamic Horizon Extension Strategy

To overcome the "local minimum trap" athe difficulty of solving long-horizon problems from scratch, we implemented a **Dynamic Horizon Extension** strategy in "trajectory generation newton.py".

The Algorithm:

1. **Start Small:** Solve the optimal control problem for a short time horizon (e.g., $T_{curr} < T_{final}$) where the goal is reachable or the DARE terminal cost effectively guides the system.
2. **Converge:** Run the Newton solver until convergence for this sub-problem.
3. **Extend:** Use the solution $x^*(t)$ from the current phase as the initial guess for an extended horizon $T_{curr} + \Delta T$. The new tail of the guess is padded with the target equilibrium.
4. **Repeat:** Iterate this process until the full task duration is covered and the terminal error is below a tolerance ($\|x_T - x_{target}\| < \epsilon$).

Results: This approach proved robust. By incrementally solving the problem, the solver is always "warm-started" with a feasible trajectory. Tasks that failed with a direct solve (like the "Topside Pump") converged reliably using this extension scheme.

4 Task 3: Trajectory Tracking via LQR

Once an optimal trajectory (x^*, u^*) is generated, we designed a **Linear Quadratic Regulator** (LQR) to stabilize the system around this trajectory in the presence of **disturbances**.
The main objective is to **minimize deviations** from the reference while ensuring **smooth control actions**, also ensuring stability at the end of the maneuver is **maintained or recovered**.

4.1 Linear Time-Varying (LTV) LQR

Since the reference trajectory is not a static point, we linearized the system dynamics along the trajectory, resulting in time-varying matrices A_t and B_t:

$$\delta x_{t+1} = A_t \delta x_t + B_t \delta u_t \tag{9}$$

The feedback law is computed as $u_t = u_t^* - K_t(x_t - x_t^*)$, where K_t is obtained by solving the Riccati equation backward in time. The input is therefore composed of the nominal **feedforward** term u_t^* and a **feedback** correction based on the state deviation.

4.2 Implementation Details

- **Perturbations:** To evaluate the controller's basin of **attraction**, we initialized the system with stochastic perturbations ($\epsilon \sim U[-0.05, 0.05]$) and then, for each run, we decided to apply the following initial disturbance:

  $$x_0 = x_0^* + \epsilon \cdot p_{\text{scale}} \cdot rr \tag{10}$$

  Where rr is the specific run, and p_{scale} is a scaling factor. By scaling these perturbations across multiple runs, we observed the LQR's ability to recover the nominal path even when the initial state deviated significantly from the optimal starting point.

- **Horizon Extension and Terminal Stability:** To ensure consistent behavior between the trajectory generation and tracking phases, the terminal cost matrix Q_T was defined as the **solution to the Discrete Algebraic Riccati Equation** (DARE) computed at the final equilibrium point.
  This choice effectively incorporates an infinite-horizon cost-to-go into the finite-horizon LQR framework, allowing the controller to **transition from a trajectory tracker into a steady-state regulator**.
  As shown in the extended simulations, the LQR continues to operate beyond the nominal time T to demonstrate the *asymptotic stability* of the closed-loop system.
  It is important to note that the validity of this terminal regulation relies on the **final trajectory state being a true equilibrium point**.
  This ensures that the linearized dynamics used for the DARE remain a faithful approximation of the nonlinear system, allowing the LQR to stabilize the robot within the neighborhood of the target pose even in the presence of residual perturbations.

- **Cost Function:** The weighting matrices Q, R, and Q_T were chosen to **balance state deviation penalties and control effort**, tuned through simulations to achieve desired performance.
  In this case, differently from the trajectory generation phase, we opted for a higher weight on the control effort (R matrix) to **avoid aggressive maneuvers** during tracking.
  Furthermore, given the flexible nature of the robot, high-gain tracking ($Q \gg R$) could **excite high-frequency oscillations** or lead to saturation in a real-world scenario.

4.3 Simulation Results

The results (see Figure 17, 19, 21) demonstrate that the LTV-LQR effectively rejects initial disturbances and tracks the complex optimal maneuver. It is possible to observe how the final stabilization of the second term is left onto the first arm, which oscillates to neglect the perturbations on the second link, and only later it will stabilize. However, there are cases in which the initial perturbation is too large for the LQR to recover the nominal trajectory, leading to divergence (see Figure 23).



Figure 17: Trajectory tracking on a downward maneuver

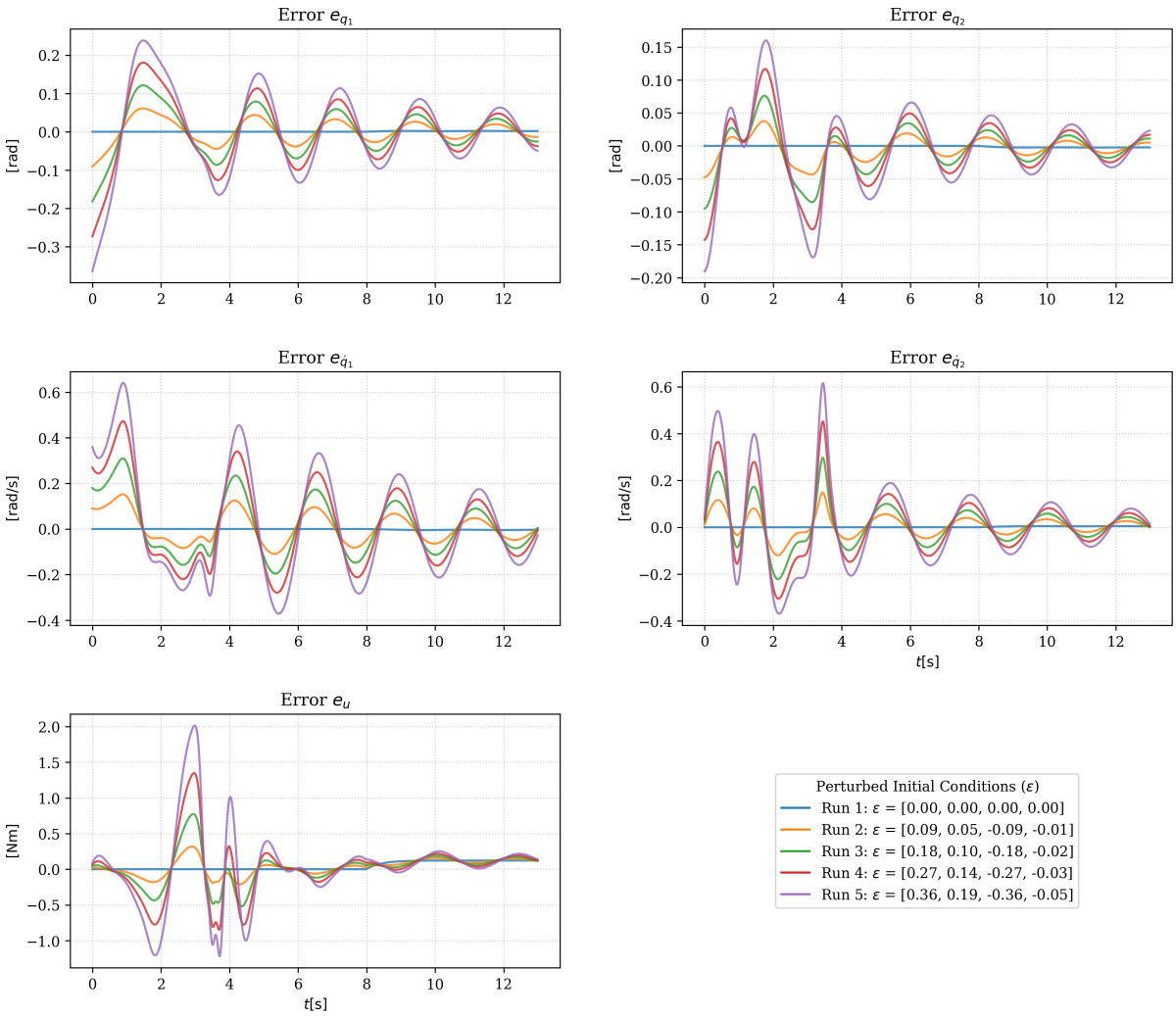


Figure 18: Error analysis during LQR tracking of downward maneuver

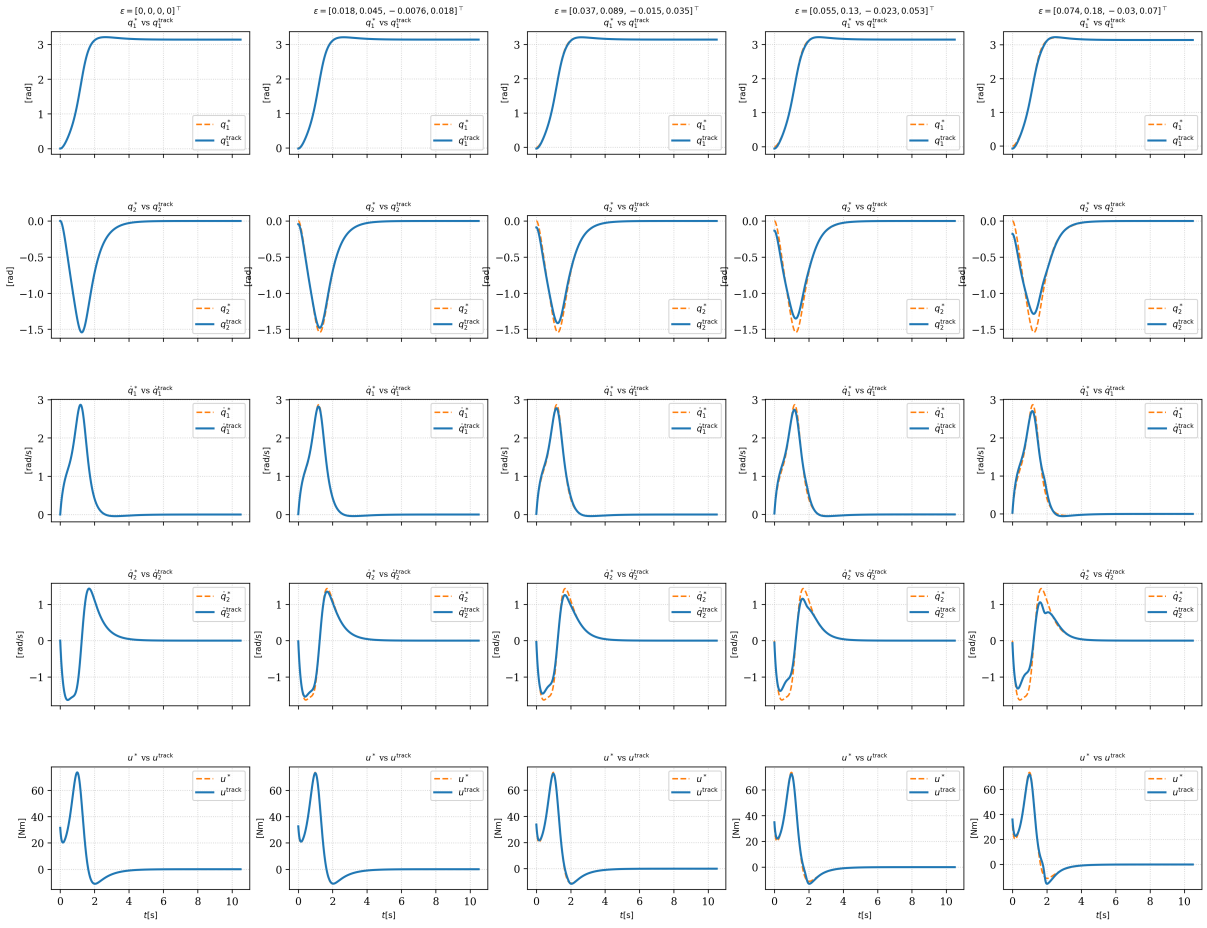


Figure 19: Trajectory tracking on a swing-up maneuver

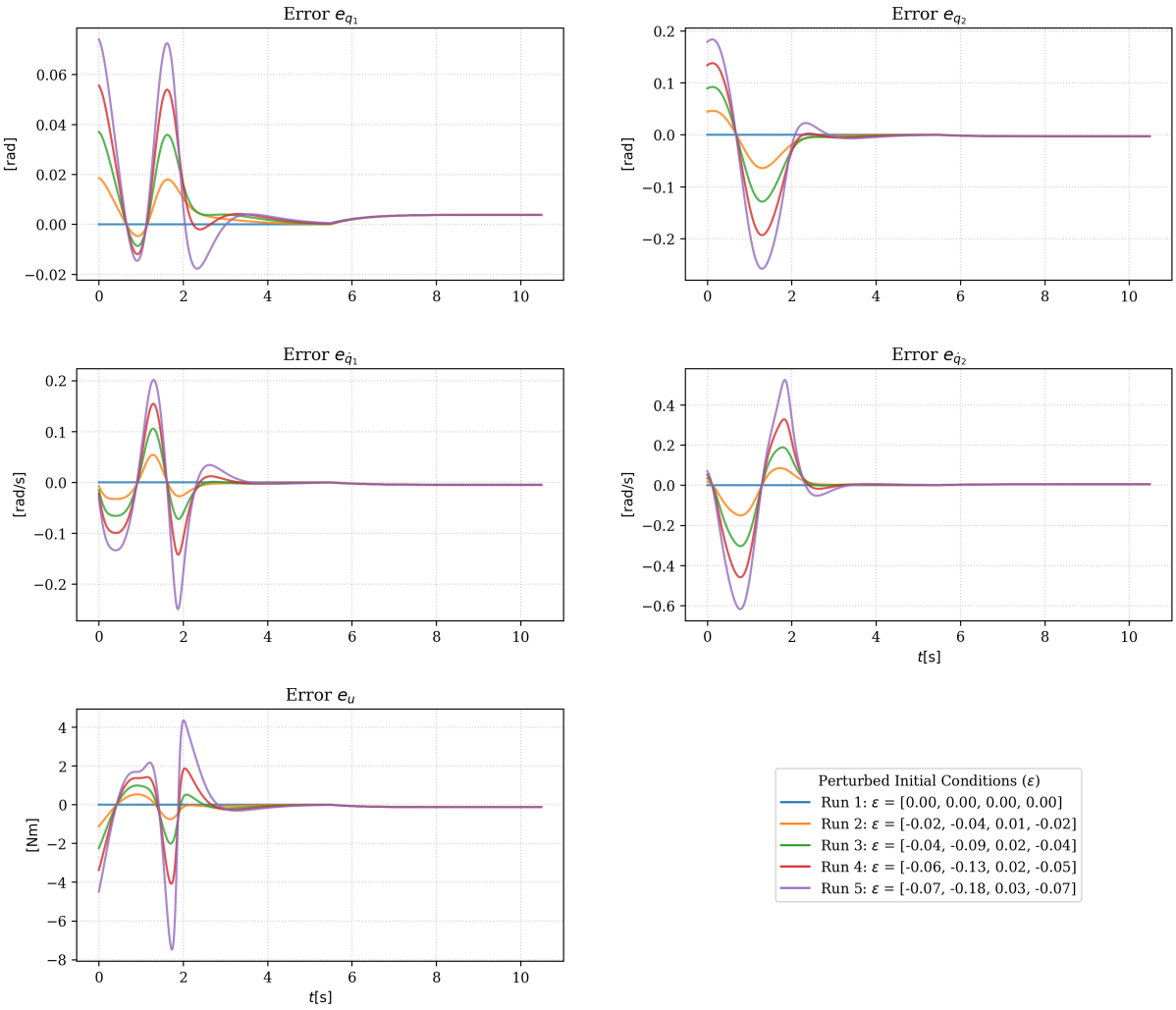


Figure 20: Error analysis during LQR tracking

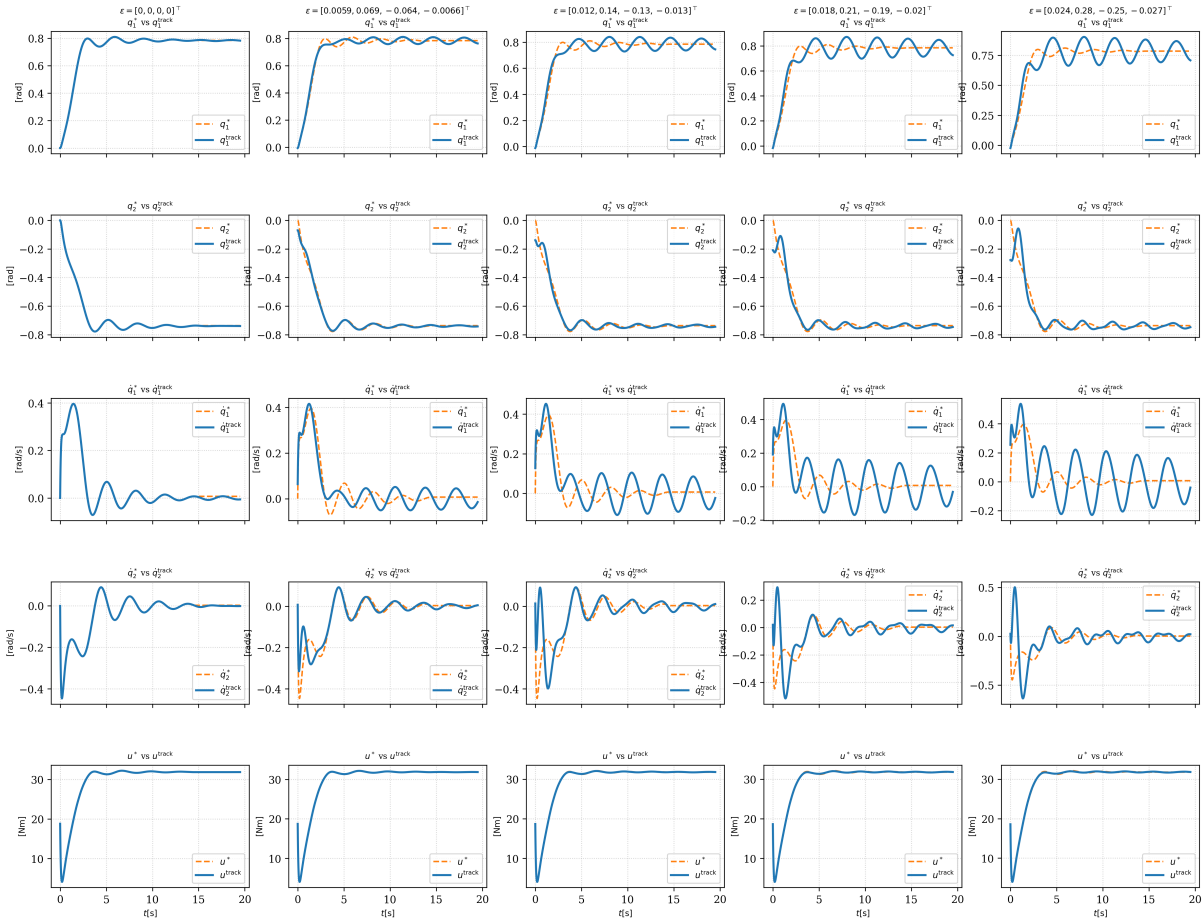


Figure 21: Trajectory tracking on a hold maneuver

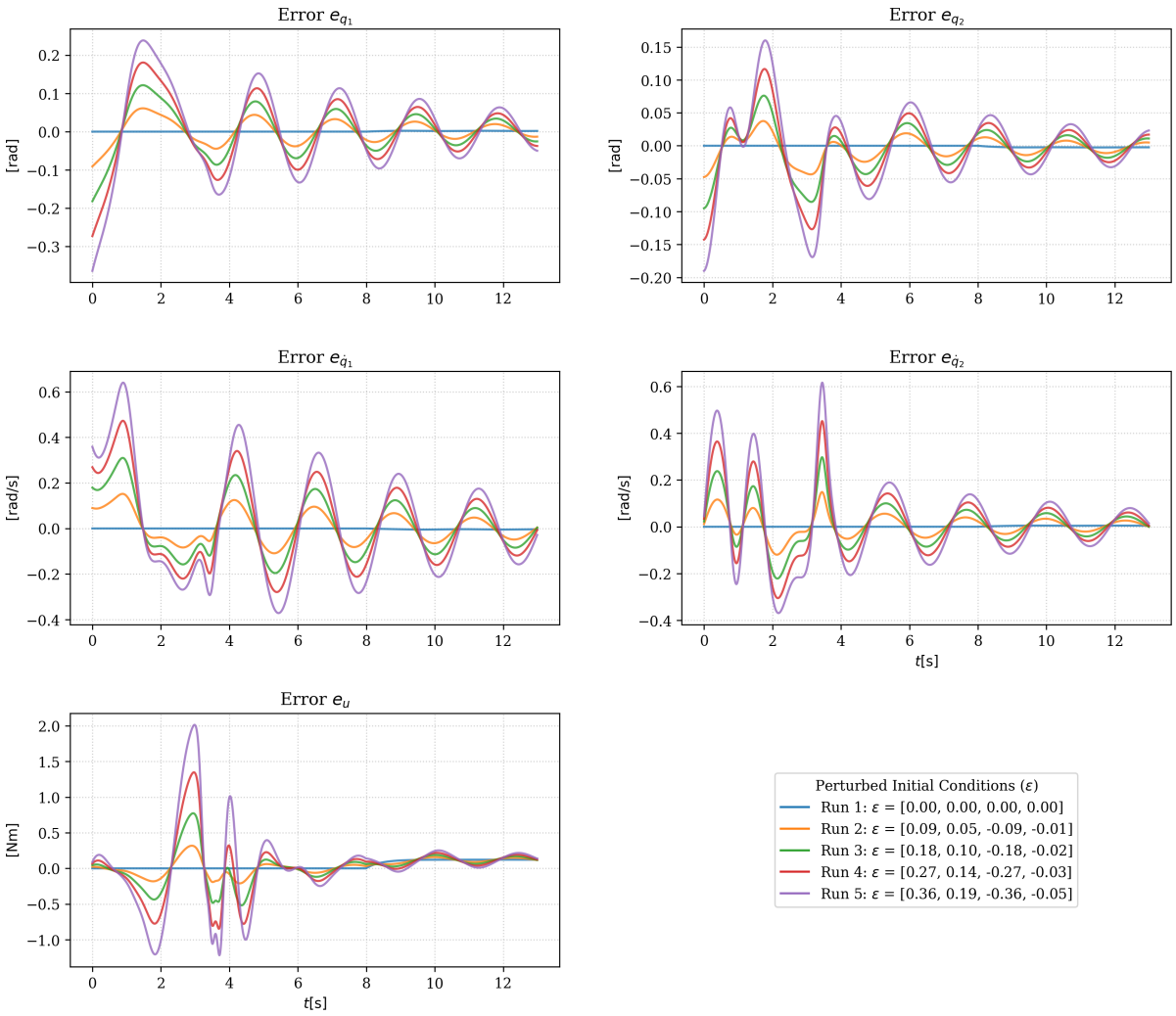


Figure 22: Error analysis during LQR tracking

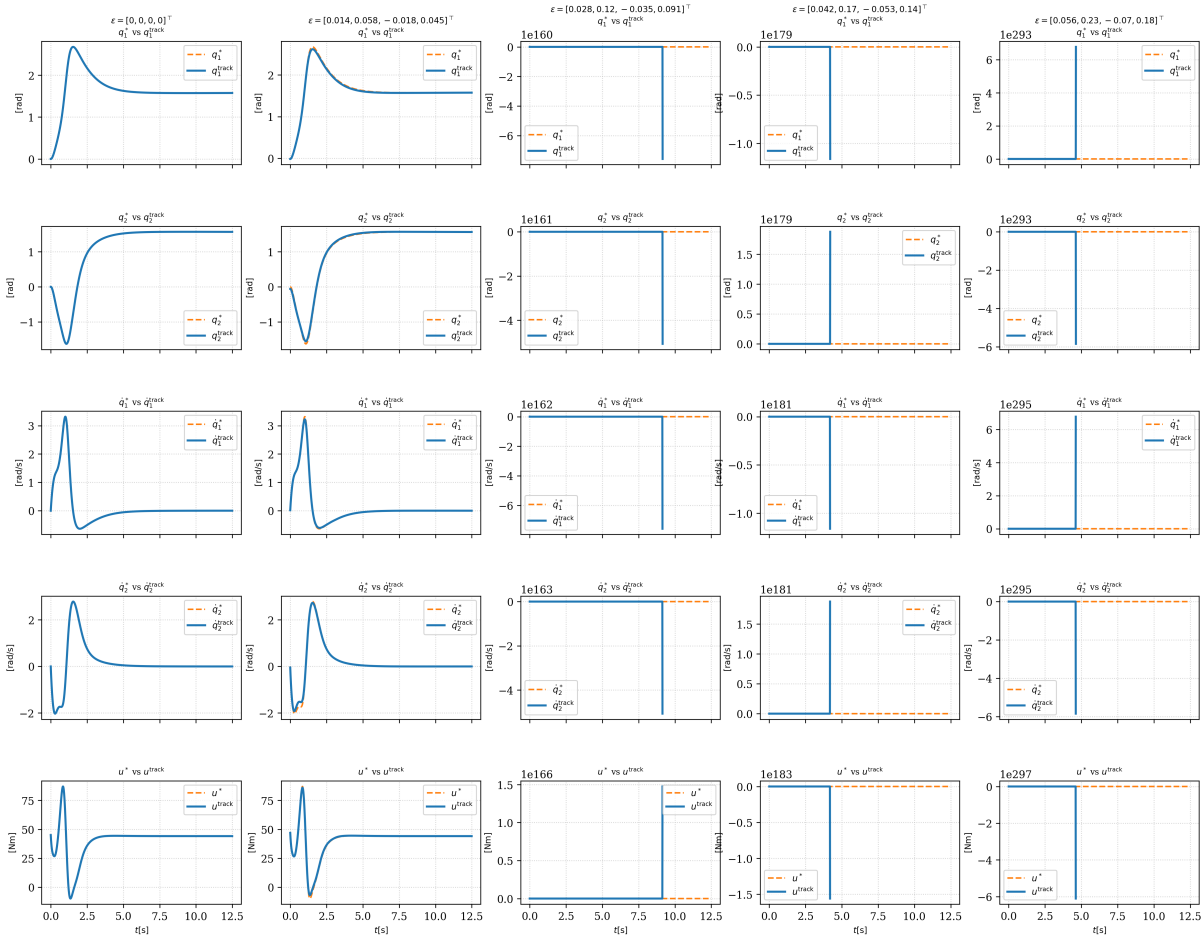


Figure 23: Trajectory tracking on a elbow up maneuver

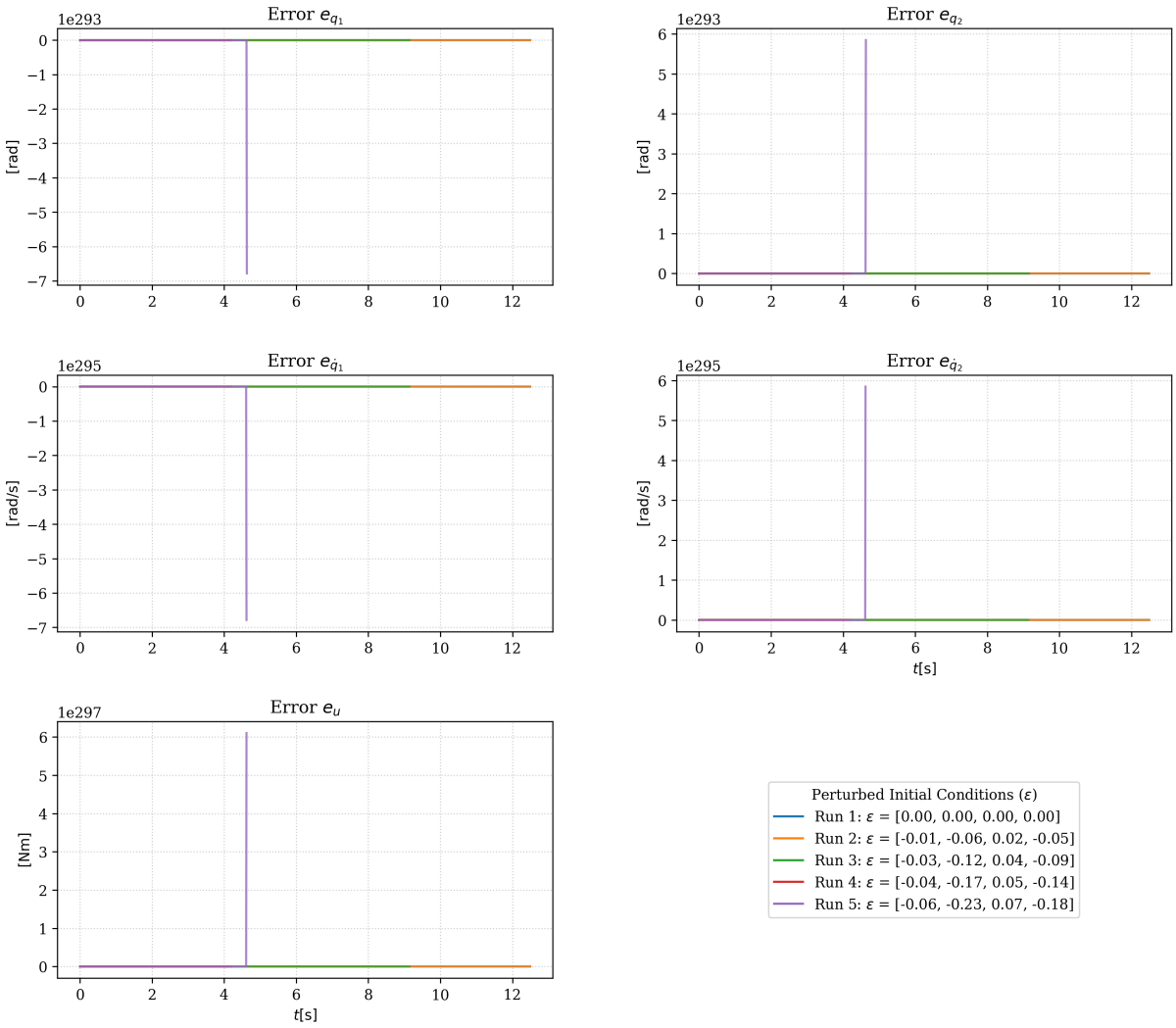


Figure 24: Error analysis during LQR tracking

5 Task 4: Trajectory Tracking via MPC

While LQR is effective for unconstrained tracking, it **cannot explicitly handle actuator saturation**. We implemented a linear **Model Predictive Control** (MPC) scheme to address this.

5.1 MPC Formulation

At each time step t, we solve a finite-horizon optimization problem:

$$\begin{aligned} \min_{\Delta u} \quad & \sum_{t=\tau}^{\tau+T_{pred}} \left(\|\Delta x_\tau\|_Q^2 + \|\Delta u_\tau\|_R^2\right) + \|\Delta x_{T_{pred}}\|_{Q_T}^2 \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & \Delta x_{t+1} = A_t \Delta x_t + B_t \Delta u_t, \quad \forall t = \tau, ..., \tau + T_{pred} \\ & u_{min} \leq u_t^* + \Delta u_t \leq u_{max}, \quad \forall t = \tau, ..., \tau + T_{pred} \end{aligned}$$

where T_{pred} is the prediction horizon.

5.2 Key Features

- **Constraints:** We imposed hard constraints on the input torque ($u \in [u_{min}, u_{max}]$) to **respect physical motor limits**, which LQR ignores.
  In particular, we set $u_{max} = \max(|u^*|)$ and $u_{min} = -u_{max}$, so as **not to exceed the torque needed to complete the nominal trajectory** with no disturbances; managing to find a way through thanks to the prediction window and the optimization.
- **Receding Horizon:** Only the first control input is applied, and the optimization is repeated at the next step. Furthermore we opted for a prediction horizon T_{pred}
  that could serve as a **good compromise between performance and computational load**. In particular, we set $T_{pred} = \min(100, \frac{\text{len}(time)}{2})$.
- **Perturbations:** Similar to the LQR case, we introduced random initial state perturbations to evaluate robustness. We opted for bigger values, about 1.5 times those used in the LQR case.
- **Solver:** We utilized CasADi with IPOPT to solve the constrained QP/NLP at each step.

5.3 Simulation Results

The MPC controller showed superior performance in scenarios where large perturbations would cause an LQR controller to request infeasible torques.
Moreover, the ability to handle constraints makes MPC a versatile choice.
Down below some results are shown (see Figure 25, 27, 29). One can notice how, in some cases, the knowledge of the future helps in recovering the reference trajectory and final equilibrium, and other cases in
which **the window and/or the constraints do not allow the controller to return to the nominal path** (as in Figure 27). Above all, the controller **never exceeds the maximum torque defined**, showing the effectiveness of the constraints in the optimization problem.

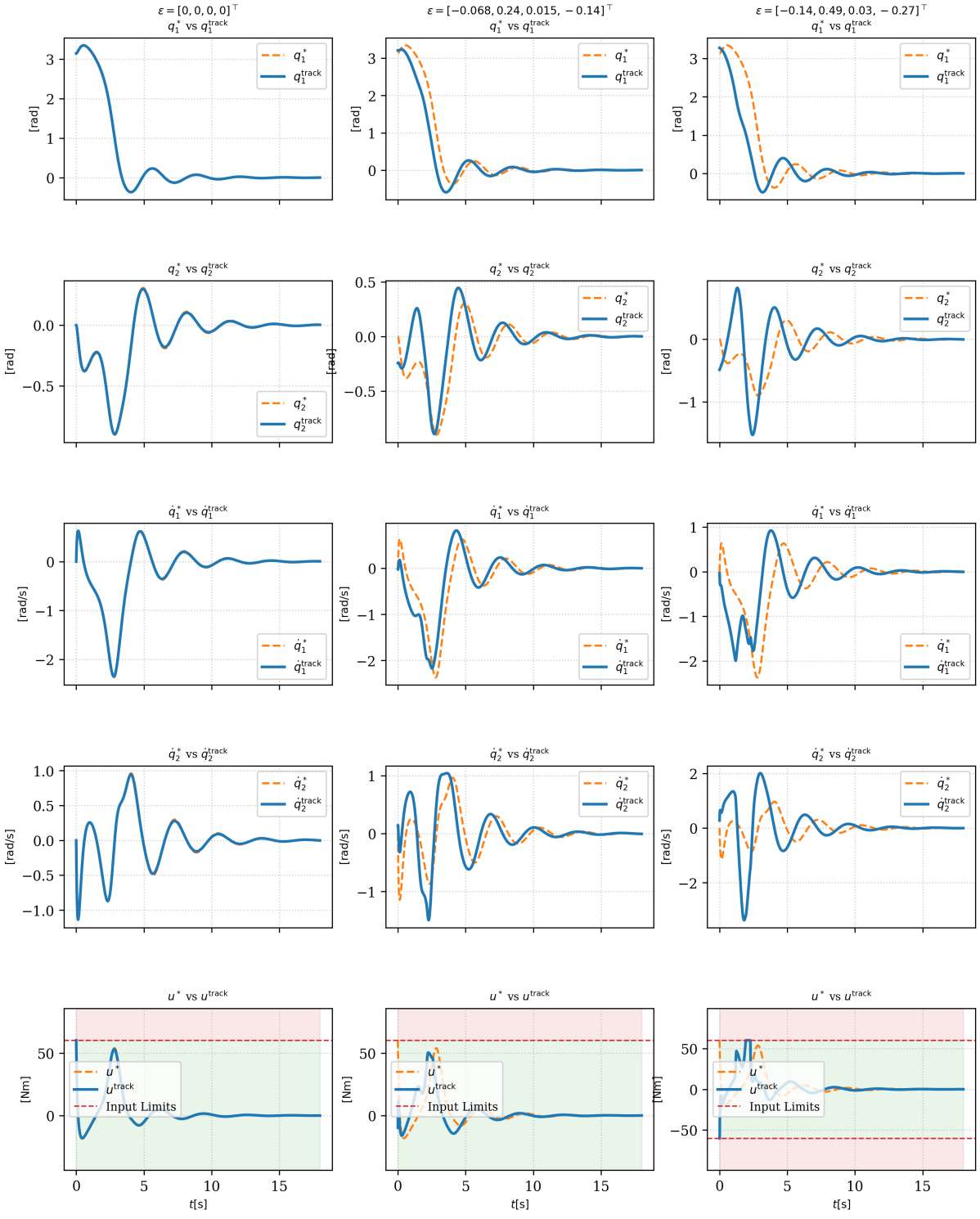


Figure 25: Trajectory tracking on a dive maneuver

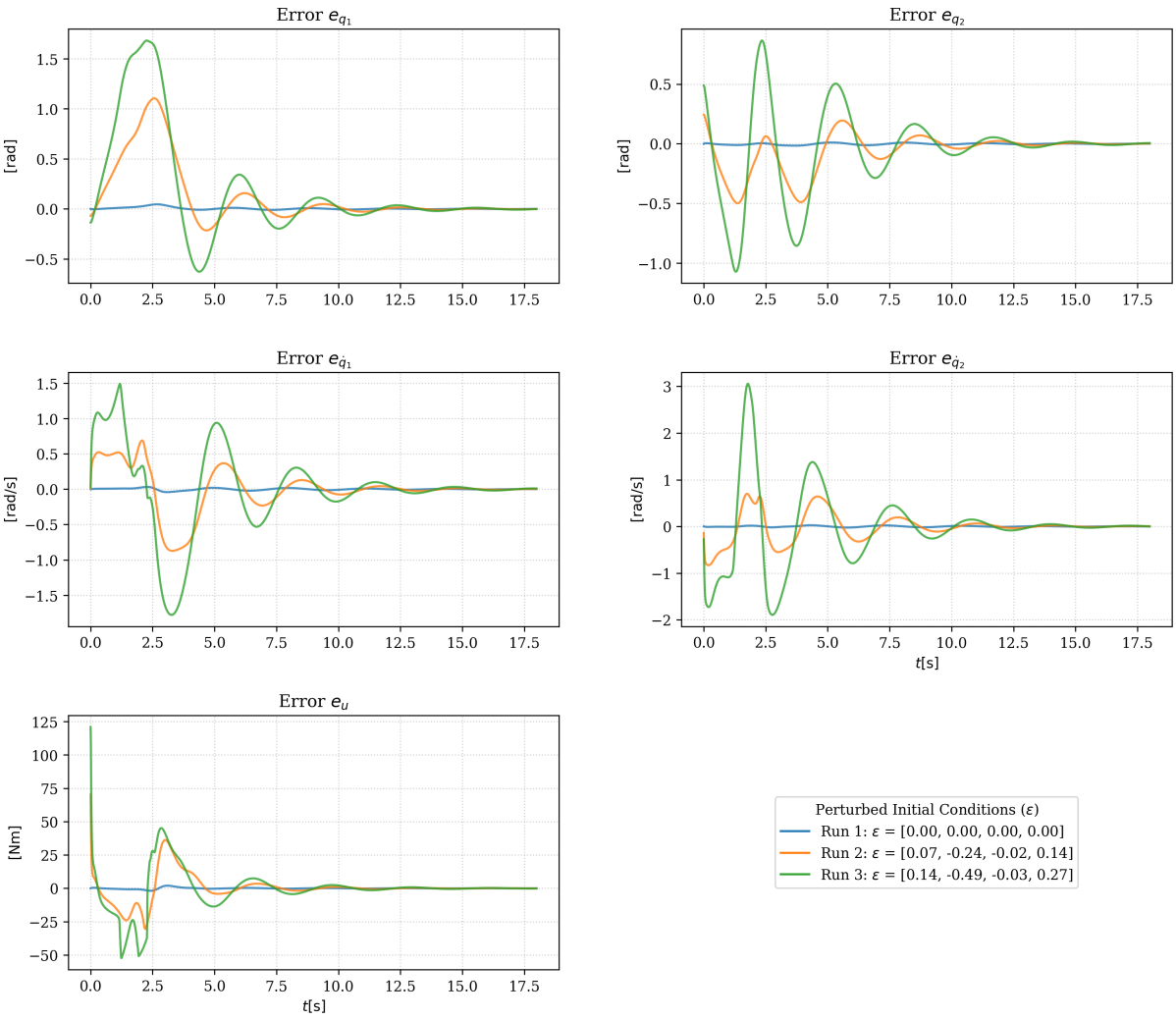


Figure 26: Error analysis during MPC tracking of dive maneuver

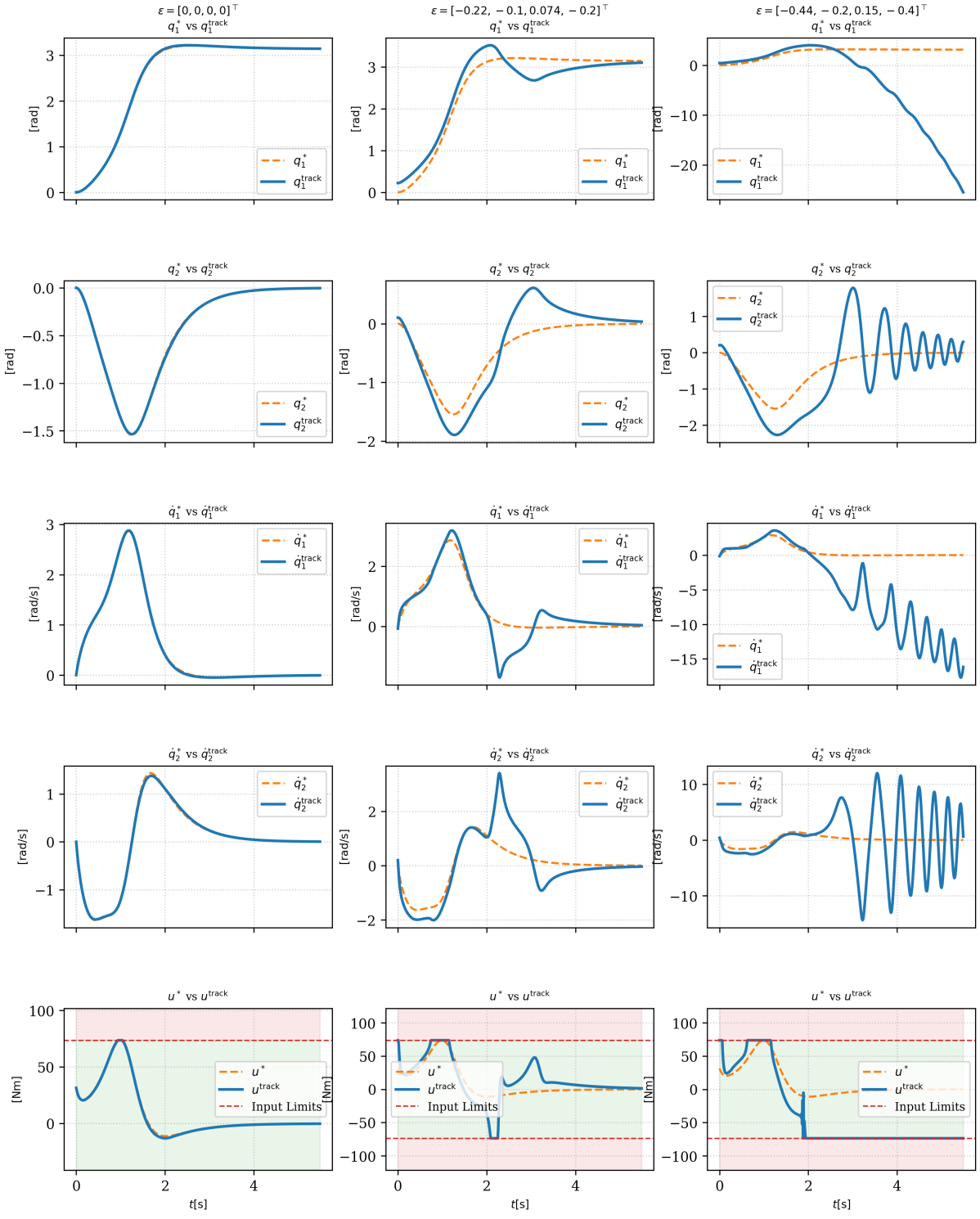


Figure 27: Trajectory tracking on a swing up maneuver

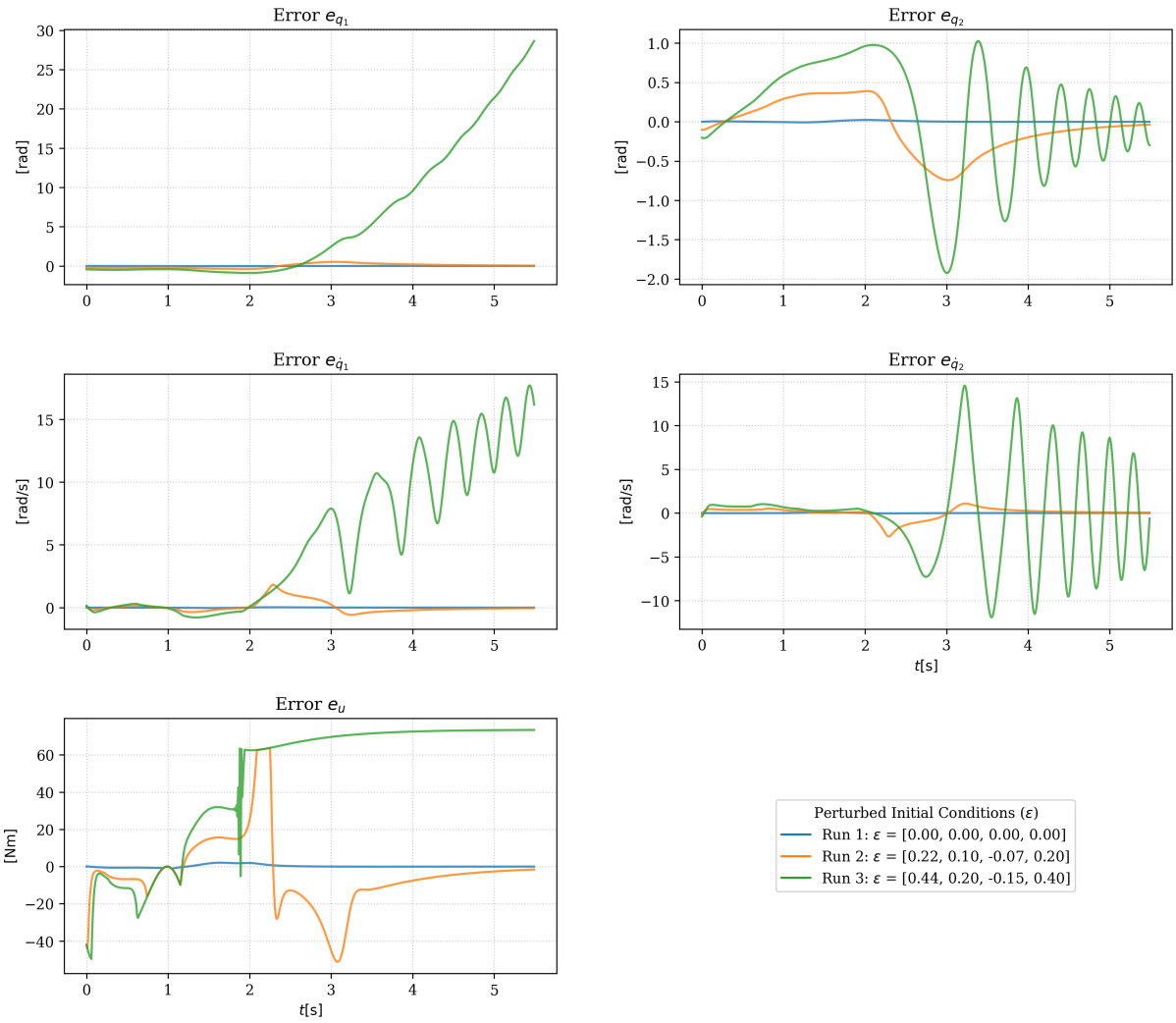


Figure 28: Error analysis during MPC tracking of swing up maneuver

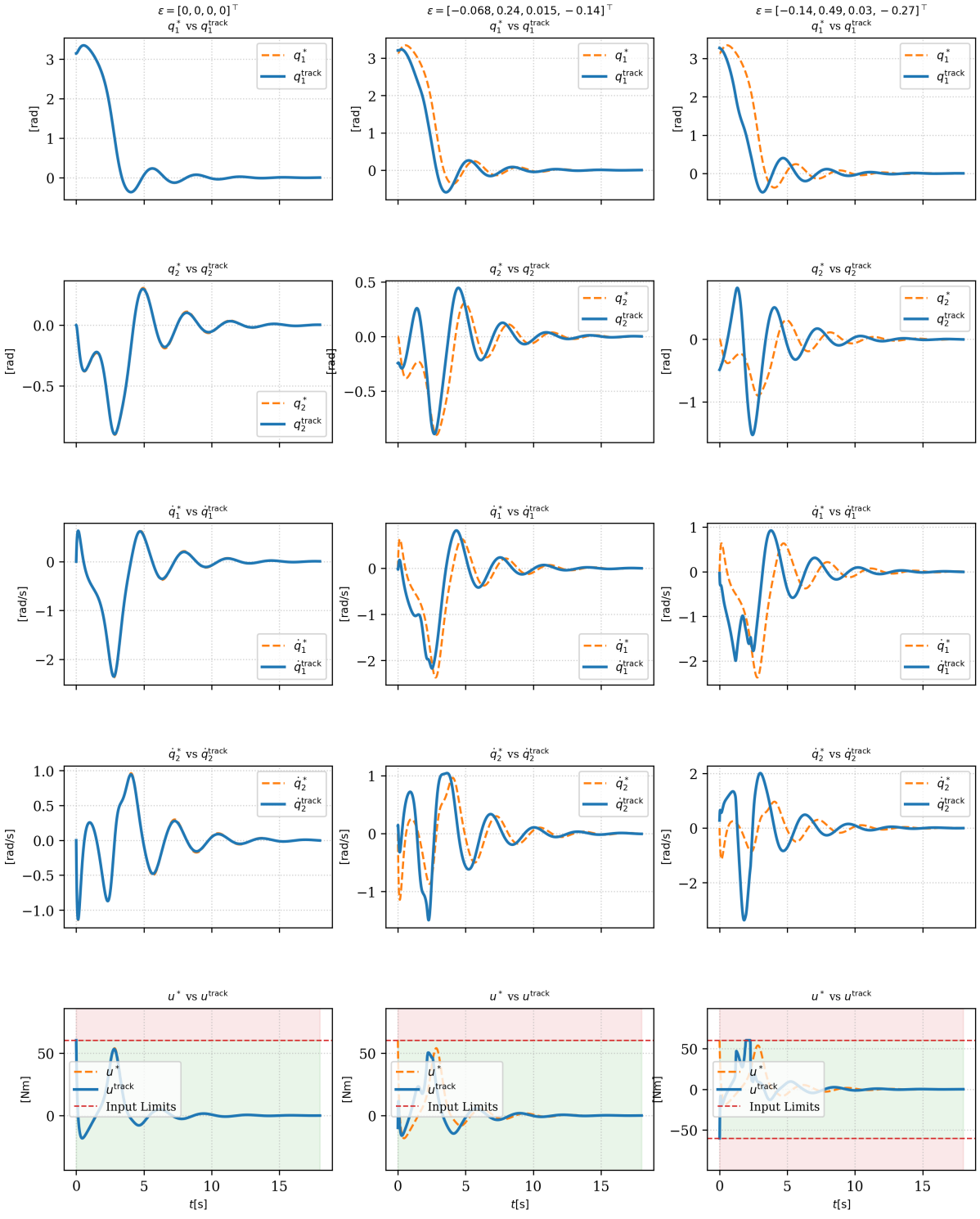


Figure 29: Trajectory tracking on a elbow up maneuver

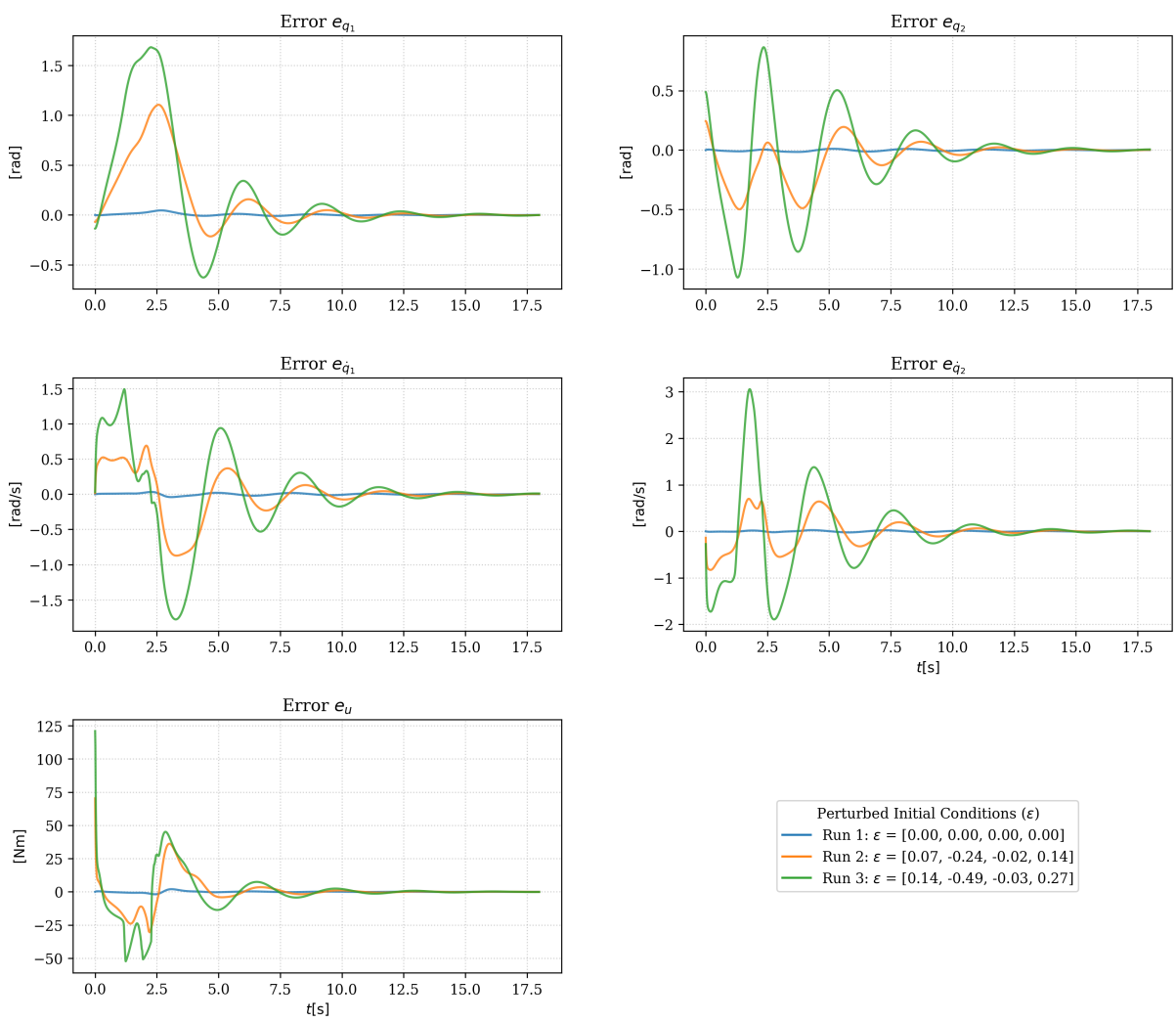


Figure 30: Error analysis during MPC tracking of a elbow maneuver

6 Task 5: Animation

6.1 Visualization

An animation suite was developed (‘animation.py‘) to visualize the results. It displays the double pendulum link, the reference trajectory (ghost), and the actual tracked path. This visual verification was crucial for debugging the "elbow-flip" behaviors inherent in the nonlinear stiffness model.

7 Conclusion

This project successfully demonstrated the control of a flexible under-actuated link.

- The **analytic Jacobian** and **RK4 discretization** provided the necessary precision for optimization.
- The **DARE-based terminal cost** significantly improved the stability of finite-horizon approximations.
- The **Dynamic Horizon Extension** strategy was the key enabler for generating complex trajectories, effectively bypassing local minima issues common in nonlinear optimization.
- Finally, **LQR and MPC** proved effective for tracking, with MPC offering the critical advantage of handling actuator constraints.

8 Introduction: The Issue with Long Horizon

In the field of nonlinear trajectory optimization, particularly when applying Newton-type methods to discrete-time systems, fundamental instability is often observed when attempting to generate long-horizon trajectories ($T \uparrow\uparrow$) directly from scratch, mainly involving a settling to unstable equilibria.

This phenomenon, often referred to as the *instability of the Single Shooting method*, is a direct consequence of the exponential propagation of sensitivities through the system dynamics. The optimization problem aims to find a control sequence $\mathbf{u}$ that minimizes a cost function subject to the discrete dynamics:

$$x_{t+1} = A_t x_t + B_t u_t \tag{11}$$

where A_t and B_t are the Jacobians of the nonlinear possibly time-varying dynamics at time t. The conditioning of the resulting optimization problem is intrinsically linked to the spectral properties of the evolution of these matrices.

9 Sensitivity Analysis and the Evolution Matrix

The primary driver of numerical explosion is the sensitivity of the final states (e.g x_N) to initial control inputs. Expanding the discrete dynamics recursively, the state at time N (analogously for any state time t) can be expressed as a function of the initial state x_0 and the control history:

$$x_N = \left(\prod_{k=0}^{N-1} A_k \right) x_0 + \sum_{i=0}^{N-1} \left(\prod_{j=i+1}^{N-1} A_j \right) B_i u_i \tag{12}$$

Since the optimization relies on gradients and Hessians derived from these sensitivities, the term $\prod_{k=0}^{N-1} A_k$ plays a critical role. Since each x_t is plugged into the cost function, it is clear how the shape of the cost landscape is heavily influenced by matrices linearizations of the system. For example, for a linear time-invariant (LTI) approximation where $A_k \approx A$, the sensitivity of the state x_N to an early control input u_0 is given by:

$$\frac{\partial x_N}{\partial u_0} = A^{N-1} B \tag{13}$$

If the system possesses unstable modes (eigenvalues of A with magnitude $|\lambda| > 1$), the term A^{N-1} grows exponentially with the horizon length N. Analogously, if we work with trajectories that get linearized around unstable equilibria, the local A_t matrices will have eigenvalues outside the unit circle for the time they are close to those points, leading to similar exponential growth in sensitivity.

9.1 Ill-Conditioning of the Hessian

Newton's method updates the control sequence by solving a linear system involving the Hessian of the cost function, H. The step $\Delta\mathbf{u}$ is calculated as:

$$\Delta\mathbf{u} = -H^{-1}g \tag{14}$$

where g is the gradient. As N increases, the massive magnitude disparity in the sensitivity matrix A^N causes the condition number of the Hessian, $\kappa(H) = \frac{|\lambda_{\max}|}{|\lambda_{\min}|}$, to skyrocket. This leads to the following effect: infinitesimal changes in the inputs (especially first ones) imply massive changes in x_N, causing the Newton step to overshoot local minima and resulting in numerical divergence.

10 The Dwell Time Phenomenon

Let's now try to imagine an experiment where we want to throw a ball on the top of a steep hill. If we only care about reaching the top at time T, we can throw it with a certain initial velocity and eventually let it roll down the other side. However, if we want the ball to stay balanced on the hilltop for a duration of time each mN of force matters for the ball to stay perfectly balanced. The idea of planning the whole input sequence at the beginning is rather difficult. Empirical observations indeed indicate that optimization is significantly more prone to failure when the target requires maintaining an unstable equilibrium for some time compared to simply reaching it at the terminal time.

10.1 Dynamics of the Unstable Equilibrium

Maintaining a state x_{eq} where the local linearization A has unstable eigenvalues requires the control input to perfectly cancel the natural divergence of the system at every time step (if it can!!!).

- **Passing Through:** When targeting the equilibrium only at the final time T, the system spends the majority of the trajectory in the transient phase. The solver exploits the system's natural momentum, and the cumulative sensitivity product is not dominated by the unstable eigenspace for long durations.
- **Dwelling:** When forced to stay at the unstable equilibrium, any numerical error ϵ at some initial t is amplified by A^k over the dwell duration. For a mode with $\lambda = 1.01$ and a dwell of 300 steps, the error amplification is $1.01^{300} \approx 19.788$.

This creates a "narrow ridge" in the optimization landscape. The solver must find a control sequence that balances on this ridge; a slight deviation results in a massive penalty gradient, often pushing the variables into the numerical overflow region.

11 System Theoretic Guarantees: Controllability and Stabilizability

The ability of the Newton solver to find a solution is mathematically bounded by the structural properties of the system: Controllability and Stabilizability.

11.1 The PBH Test

While standard controllability checks the rank of the Kalman controllability matrix $[B, AB, \ldots, A^{n-1}B]$, numerical conditioning is better assessed via the Popov-Belevitch-Hautus (PBH) test. A system

is stabilizable if and only if:

$$\text{rank}([\lambda I - A \mid B]) = n \quad \forall \lambda \in \mathbb{C}, \quad |\lambda| \geq 1 \tag{15}$$

In underactuated systems (our case), kinematic singularities can cause this rank to drop (in our case we control only through coupling!). If the rank deficiency occurs at an unstable eigenvalue, the mode is *uncontrollable* and *unstable*. In such configurations, the Hessian becomes singular, and the Newton step is undefined.

11.2 The DARE and Terminal Cost

Infinite-horizon stability is often approximated using the solution P_∞ to the Discrete Algebraic Riccati Equation (DARE):

$$P = A^\top PA - (A^\top PB)(R + B^\top PB)^{-1}(B^\top PA) + Q \tag{16}$$

The existence of a unique positive semi-definite solution P_∞ strictly requires that the pair (A, B) be *stabilizable* and $(A, Q^{1/2})$ be *detectable*. If the trajectory enters a region where local stabilizability is lost (i.e., the PBH test fails for an unstable mode), the DARE solution P_∞ loses its guarantees to asimptotically stabilize the system. Consequently, the cost in the optimization may become effectively infinite, causing the solver to crash.

12 Mitigation Strategy

To circumvent the ill-conditioning caused by A^N and ensuring valid linearization regions, a *Horizon Extension* (or Continuation) strategy is employed. Returning to our ball-on-hill analogy, instead of throwing the ball directly to the top and trying to balance it there, we first try to reach the target height at T. Later, we incrementally extend the horizon, using the previously computed trajectory as a warm start for the next optimization. Basically, we are asking the task to stay just a bit longer each time. This approach leverages three key advantages:

1. **Short Horizon Initialization:** Optimizing for a small T ensures that the sensitivity matrix A^T remains bounded. The Hessian is well-conditioned, and the basin of attraction for Newton's method is large.

2. **Warm Starting:** The solution from the short horizon T serves as the initial guess for $T + \Delta T$. This effectively "anchors" the trajectory in a feasible region of the state space.

3. **Iterative Refinement:** As T extends, the solver only needs to refine the control inputs locally. Since the trajectory is already close to physical feasibility, the quadratic approximation holds, and the solver avoids the explosive divergence associated with global search in ill-conditioned landscapes.

This approach effectively conditions the "evolution matrix" of the optimization by solving a sequence of well-posed problems rather than a single, numerically hazardous one.

13 Appendix

13.1 Models matrices and parameters

$$M(q) = \begin{bmatrix} I_1 + I_2 + l_{c1}^2 m_1 + m_2(l_1^2 + 2l_1 l_{c2}\cos(\theta_2) + l_{c2}^2) & I_2 + l_{c2} m_2 (l_1 \cos(\theta_2) + l_{c2}) \\ I_2 + l_{c2} m_2 (l_1 \cos(\theta_2) + l_{c2}) & I_2 + l_{c2}^2 m_2 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$C(q, \dot{q}) = \begin{bmatrix} -l_1 l_{c2} m_2 \dot{\theta}_2 \sin(\theta_2) & -l_1 l_{c2} m_2 (\dot{\theta}_1 + \dot{\theta}_2) \sin(\theta_2) \\ l_1 l_{c2} m_2 \dot{\theta}_1 \sin(\theta_2) & 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$G(q) = \begin{bmatrix} g l_{c1} m_1 \sin(\theta_1) + g m_2 (l_1 \sin(\theta_1) + l_{c2} \sin(\theta_1 + \theta_2)) \\ g m_2 l_{c2} \sin(\theta_1 + \theta_2) + 3k \sin(\theta_2) \cos^2(\theta_2) \end{bmatrix}$$

$$F = \begin{bmatrix} f_1 & 0 \\ 0 & f_2 \end{bmatrix}$$

Symbol	Description	Value	Unit
m_1, m_2	Mass of link 1 and 2	2	kg
l_1, l_2	Length of link 1 and 2	1.5	m
r_1, r_2	Distance to center of mass	0.75	m
I_1, I_2	Moment of inertia	1.5	$\mathrm{kg\,m^2}$
g	Gravitational acceleration	9.81	$\mathrm{m/s^2}$
f_1, f_2	Viscous friction coefficient	1.0	$\mathrm{N\,m\,s/rad}$
k	Nonlinear angular stiffness	0.6	$\mathrm{N\,m/rad}$

Table 1: Model Parameters (Set 2)

13.2 Analytical Derivation of the Jacobian

This appendix details the analytical computation of the Jacobian matrices A and B used in the linearization of the flexible double pendulum dynamics.

13.2.1 State-Space Formulation

Consider the state space formulation given in Section 1.

$$\dot{x} = \begin{bmatrix} \dot{q} \\ \ddot{q} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} \dot{q} \\ M(q)^{-1} \left(\tau - C(q, \dot{q})\dot{q} - G(q) - F\dot{q}\right) \end{bmatrix} \tag{17}$$

$$\dot{x} = f(x, u)$$

To linearize the system about a point $(\bar{x}, \bar{u})$, we compute the State and Input Jacobians:

$$A = \left.\frac{\partial f(x,u)}{\partial x}\right|_{\bar{x},\bar{u}} \in \mathbb{R}^{4\times 4} \quad B = \left.\frac{\partial f(x,u)}{\partial u}\right|_{\bar{x},\bar{u}} \in \mathbb{R}^{4\times 1}$$

The state Jacobian $A \in \mathbb{R}^{4\times 4}$ has the following block structure:

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} \frac{\partial \dot{q}}{\partial q} & \frac{\partial \dot{q}}{\partial \dot{q}} \\ \frac{\partial \ddot{q}}{\partial q} & \frac{\partial \ddot{q}}{\partial \dot{q}} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 0_{2\times 2} & I_{2\times 2} \\ A_{21} & A_{22} \end{bmatrix} \tag{18}$$

13.2.2 Block A_{22}: Partial Derivative w.r.t. Velocities

Let $\eta = \tau - C(q,\dot{q})\dot{q} - G(q) - F\dot{q}$ be the net torque. Then $\ddot{q} = M^{-1}\eta$. Since M and G depend only on positions q, the derivative with respect to $\dot{q}$ is:

$$A_{22} = \frac{\partial \ddot{q}}{\partial \dot{q}} = M^{-1}\left(-\frac{\partial (C(q,\dot{q})\dot{q})}{\partial \dot{q}} - F\right) \tag{19}$$

13.2.3 Block A_{21}: Partial Derivative w.r.t. Positions

The derivative with respect to q involves the chain rule on both the inverse mass matrix and the force vector η:

$$A_{21} = \frac{\partial \ddot{q}}{\partial q} = \underbrace{\frac{\partial (M^{-1})}{\partial q}\eta}_{\text{term 1}} + \underbrace{M^{-1}\frac{\partial \eta}{\partial q}}_{\text{term 2}} \tag{20}$$

Term 1: Derivative of Inverse Mass Matrix Using the identity $\frac{\partial M^{-1}}{\partial \alpha} = -M^{-1}\frac{\partial M}{\partial \alpha}M^{-1}$, the first term is computed column-wise for q_1 and q_2:

$$\frac{\partial (M^{-1})}{\partial q_i}\eta = -M^{-1}\frac{\partial M}{\partial q_i}M^{-1}\eta = -M^{-1}\frac{\partial M}{\partial q_i}\ddot{q} \tag{21}$$

Term 2: Derivative of Forces The derivative of the net torque η with respect to q is:

$$\frac{\partial \eta}{\partial q} = -\frac{\partial (C(q,\dot{q})\dot{q})}{\partial q} - \frac{\partial G}{\partial q} \tag{22}$$

13.2.4 Jacobian Matrix B

The input Jacobian $B \in \mathbb{R}^{4\times 1}$ is straightforward, as only the torque τ depends on u:

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} \frac{\partial \dot{q}}{\partial u} \\ \frac{\partial \ddot{q}}{\partial u} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 0_{2\times 1} \\ M^{-1}\frac{\partial \tau}{\partial u} \end{bmatrix} \tag{23}$$

Since $\tau = [u, 0]^\top$, $\frac{\partial \tau}{\partial u} = [1, 0]^\top$. Thus, the bottom block of B is simply the first column of M^{-1}.

13.2.5 Explicit Derivative Matrices

For completeness, the non-zero partial derivatives implemented in the code are listed below. Let $s_i = \sin(q_i)$, $c_i = \cos(q_i)$, $s_{ij} = \sin(q_i + q_j)$, $c_{ij} = \cos q_i + q_j$.

Gravity Gradient

$$\frac{\partial G}{\partial q} = \begin{bmatrix} g(m_1 l_{c1} + m_2 l_1)c_1 + m_2 g l_{c2} c_{12} & m_2 g l_{c2} c_{12} \\ m_2 g l_{c2} c_{12} & m_2 g l_{c2} c_{12} + 3k(c_2^2 - 2s_2^2)c_2 \end{bmatrix} \tag{24}$$

Coriolis Velocity Gradient

$$\frac{\partial (C\dot{q})}{\partial \dot{q}} = 2m_2 l_1 l_{c2} s_2 \begin{bmatrix} -\dot{q}_2 & -(\dot{q}_1 + \dot{q}_2) \\ \dot{q}_1 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \tag{25}$$

Mass Matrix Gradient

$$\frac{\partial M}{\partial q_2} = -m_2 l_1 l_{c2} s_2 \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \tag{26}$$

13.3 Derivation of Discrete-Time Jacobians

This appendix details the linearization of the discrete-time dynamics obtained via numerical integration. Let the continuous-time dynamics be $\dot{x} = f(x, u)$, and let the discrete-time system be denoted by:

$$x_{k+1} = F(x_k, u_k) \tag{27}$$

where F is the numerical integration map over a time step Δt. We seek the discrete-time state Jacobian A_d and input Jacobian B_d:

$$A_d = \left.\frac{\partial F}{\partial x}\right|_{x_k,u_k}, \quad B_d = \left.\frac{\partial F}{\partial u}\right|_{x_k,u_k} \tag{28}$$

Let the continuous-time Jacobians evaluated at a specific state x and input u be denoted as $A_c(x, u) = \nabla_x f(x, u)^\top$ and $B_c(x, u) = \nabla_u f(x, u)^\top$.

13.3.1 Forward Euler Discretization

The Forward Euler method approximates the dynamics as:

$$x_{k+1} = x_k + \Delta t f(x_k, u_k) \tag{29}$$

Differentiating with respect to x_k and u_k yields the standard first-order approximation:

$$A_d = I + \Delta t A_c(x_k, u_k) \tag{30}$$
$$B_d = \Delta t B_c(x_k, u_k) \tag{31}$$

13.3.2 Runge-Kutta 4 (RK4) Discretization

The explicit RK4 integration scheme is defined by:

$$x_{k+1} = x_k + \frac{\Delta t}{6}(k_1 + 2k_2 + 2k_3 + k_4) \tag{32}$$

where the intermediate slopes k_i are:

$$\begin{aligned} k_1 &= f(x_k, u_k) \\ k_2 &= f(x_k + 0.5\Delta t k_1, u_k) \\ k_3 &= f(x_k + 0.5\Delta t k_2, u_k) \\ k_4 &= f(x_k + \Delta t k_3, u_k) \end{aligned}$$

To find A_d and B_d, we apply the chain rule recursively to the slopes k_i.

State Jacobian A_d Differentiating the update equation with respect to x_k:

$$A_d = I + \frac{\Delta t}{6}\left(\frac{\partial k_1}{\partial x} + 2\frac{\partial k_2}{\partial x} + 2\frac{\partial k_3}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial k_4}{\partial x}\right) \tag{33}$$

Let $x^{(i)}$ denote the argument of f for the calculation of k_i. The gradients are derived recursively:

$$\frac{\partial k_1}{\partial x} = A_c(x_k, u_k) \tag{34}$$
$$\frac{\partial k_2}{\partial x} = A_c(x^{(2)}, u_k)\left(I + 0.5\Delta t\frac{\partial k_1}{\partial x}\right) \tag{35}$$
$$\frac{\partial k_3}{\partial x} = A_c(x^{(3)}, u_k)\left(I + 0.5\Delta t\frac{\partial k_2}{\partial x}\right) \tag{36}$$
$$\frac{\partial k_4}{\partial x} = A_c(x^{(4)}, u_k)\left(I + \Delta t\frac{\partial k_3}{\partial x}\right) \tag{37}$$

Input Jacobian B_d Differentiating the update equation with respect to u_k:

$$B_d = \frac{\Delta t}{6}\left(\frac{\partial k_1}{\partial u} + 2\frac{\partial k_2}{\partial u} + 2\frac{\partial k_3}{\partial u} + \frac{\partial k_4}{\partial u}\right) \tag{38}$$

Note that u_k appears both directly in f and indirectly through the state perturbation in the intermediate steps. The recursive gradients are:

$$\frac{\partial k_1}{\partial u} = B_c(x_k, u_k) \tag{39}$$

$$\frac{\partial k_2}{\partial u} = A_c(x^{(2)}, u_k)\left(0.5\Delta t\frac{\partial k_1}{\partial u}\right) + B_c(x^{(2)}, u_k) \tag{40}$$

$$\frac{\partial k_3}{\partial u} = A_c(x^{(3)}, u_k)\left(0.5\Delta t\frac{\partial k_2}{\partial u}\right) + B_c(x^{(3)}, u_k) \tag{41}$$

$$\frac{\partial k_4}{\partial u} = A_c(x^{(4)}, u_k)\left(\Delta t\frac{\partial k_3}{\partial u}\right) + B_c(x^{(4)}, u_k) \tag{42}$$

This exact linearization of the RK4 integrator ensures that the discrete-time Jacobians accurately reflect the curvature of the numerical integration path, which is critical for the stability of Newton-based optimal control solvers.